

**BULGARIA****Capital city:** Sofia**Area:** 42,822 sq miles
(110,910 sq km)**Population:** 7,900,000**Official language:**
Bulgarian**Major religions:** Christian
85%, Muslim 13%, Jewish
1%, other 1%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Lev**Adult literacy rate:** 99%**Life expectancy:** 72 years**People per doctor:** 294**Televisions:** 398 per 1,000
people

BULGARIA

FOR MUCH OF ITS HISTORY, the area that is now Bulgaria has lived in the shadow of stronger neighbors. The Greeks, Romans, and Turks have all ruled here, and from 1944–89 Bulgaria was part of the Soviet communist bloc. Most of the population is made up of Bulgars, with sizeable minorities of Macedonians and Turks. Since the move to democracy, state-run farms have been reorganized, and western tourists are being encouraged to visit the old towns as well as lakes and resorts on the Black Sea.

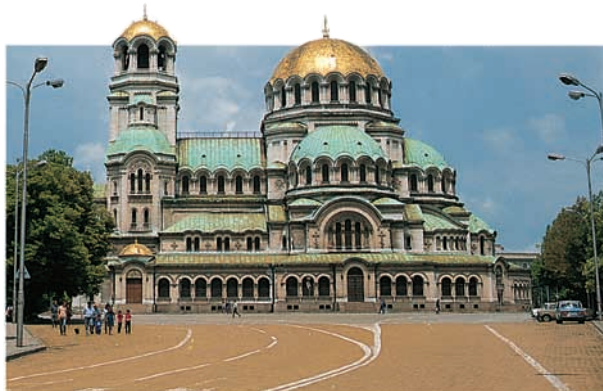


Women wear traditional costumes during the Festival of the Roses.



Damask rose

Roses are picked before fully open to avoid exposure to the sun.

**CITY OF SOFIA**

The capital city of Sofia is home to more than a million people. Set in an area of mountains and lowland dairy farming, the city is a thriving industrial center. It is also a showcase for many fine Roman buildings, as well as the Alexander Nevsky Cathedral, shown here, which was built to honor Russian soldiers who liberated Sofia from Turkish rule in 1878. Bulgaria has a good transportation system. Many people in Sofia travel by trolleys that get their power from overhead electric cables.

**FESTIVAL MASKS**

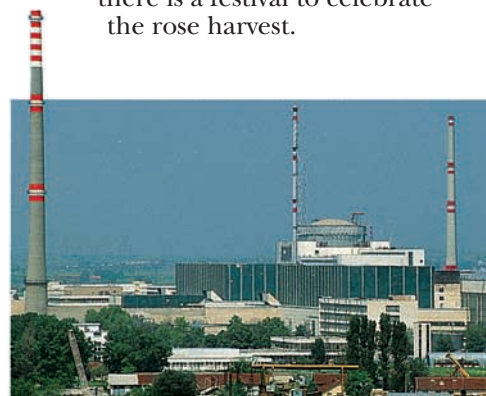
Folk customs play an important part in keeping Bulgarian traditions alive. Many towns have their own festival, featuring music and parades. People often make and paint their own masks, and decorate them with bead and ribbons.

ECONOMY

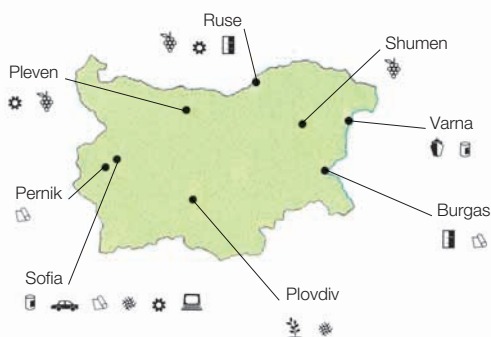
Bulgaria lacks the high-grade coal and iron necessary to support heavy industry. In the past, its factories relied on cheap supplies of coal and oil from the former USSR. Now they have to buy these on the open market. Bulgaria has been forced to arrange large loans from the West to finance development of new industries, such as computer technology. Textile mills and food processing are important.

ROSE GROWING

Situated in the foothills of the Balkan Mountains, near the town of Kazanluk, lies the Valley of the Roses. Fields of roses are grown here for their essential oil, called attar, which is used to make perfume. At dawn each day in May and June, before the sun has time to dry out their oil, blossoms of the damask rose are picked and the petals packed into sacks. These are taken by donkey cart to a distillery, where they are made into attar. Every June there is a festival to celebrate the rose harvest.

**NUCLEAR POWER**

Bulgaria does not have enough coal or power from its hydroelectric plants to provide itself with energy. Forty percent of its electricity now comes from the Kozloduy nuclear power plant. Because the plant was built by the Soviet Union, and lies in an earthquake zone, there has been great concern about its safety. Since 1990, the European Union has helped make the plant safer.

Bulgarian industries

Vehicle assembly
Engineering
Tobacco
Oil refining
Wine

Steel
Textiles
Shipbuilding
Food processing
Computers

Find out more

BREAKUP OF USSR: 136
COUNTRIES OF
EASTERN EUROPE: 80
POLITICAL SYSTEMS: 270–271